stammer	-	to speak haltingly, fumble for words
betray	-	fail, let one down
despair	-	hopelessness
downcast	-	depressed
flog	-	to beat with a whip or stick
mirth	-	cheerfulness
sledge	-	a vehicle pulled by horses for transportation on snow
wretched	-	dejected
vengeance	-	revenge

1. Answer the following questions in a sentence or two each, based on your understanding of the story.

a) Why did Aksionov's wife stop him from going to the fair?

b) What is the importance of Aksionov's wife's dream?

c) What made Aksionov leave the inn before dawn?

d) What were the circumstances that led to Aksionov's imprisonment?

e) Why did Aksionov give up sending petitions?

f) Why didn't Makar disclose that he had killed the merchant?

g) Did Makar feel guilty when he heard Aksionov's story?

h) What made Aksionov think that Makar was the real murderer?

i) What was Aksionov's realization by the end of the story?

j) Why did Aksionov's wife suspect him of involvement in the murder?

2. Answer the following questions in three or four sentences each.

a) Did the police officer have sufficient evidence to convict Aksionov?

b) What impact did the book "The Lives of Saints" have on Aksionov?

c) Pick out the clues that convey that Makar Semyonich recognized Aksionov.

3. Answer the following questions in a paragraph in about 150 words each.

a) Compare and contrast the main characters, Aksionov and Makar Semyonich, in the story.

b) How did Aksionov react when his wife suspected him?

c) Describe the life of Aksionov in prison.

d) Why did Aksionov decide not to reveal the truth about Makar Semyonich?

e) Discuss the meaning and importance of the saying "God sees the truth but waits".

f) Forgiveness is the best form of revenge. Substantiate the statement with reference to the story.

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